

D570

Cognitive Psychology

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A pharmacist at a busy chain store with a drive-through reads a smudged handwritten note that looks like “Take 1 t_blet daily” and immediately reads it as “tablet.” The note was written on blue paper. Which process allowed her to fill in the missing letter?

- A. Sensory adaptation.
- B. Bottom-up processing.
- C. Color cues from the blue paper.
- D. Top-down processing.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A person sees an unfamiliar abstract shape for the first time and identifies it by detecting its lines, angles, and edges. Which process is this?

- A. Top-down processing.
- B. Bottom-up processing.
- C. Prototype matching, since all perception compares to a stored ideal.
- D. Chunking.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

Radiologists at a teaching hospital with a new MRI wing are asked to search lung scans for nodules. In one scan, a small image of a gorilla is placed in the lung, and most radiologists miss it despite looking directly at that area. The study took place on a Tuesday. What best explains this?

- A. Lack of expertise.
- B. Change blindness.
- C. Poor eyesight, since anything in view is always noticed.
- D. Inattentional blindness.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A nurse who plays guitar on weekends must remember an 11-digit account number: 18005551234. She thinks of it as “1-800,” “555,” and “1234,” which are familiar patterns. The number was printed on a green card. Into how many chunks has she grouped the digits?

- A. 4
- B. 7
- C. 3
- D. 11

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A person can hold about 4 chunks in working memory. If each chunk is a familiar 3-letter acronym, about how many letters can she hold?

- A. About 4
- B. About 1.3
- C. About 12
- D. About 7

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

In a study run in a lab with soundproof walls, group A decides whether each word is printed in capital letters, and group B decides whether each word fits the sentence “She put the ___ on the table.” The words appeared on a gray screen. Which result is expected on a surprise recall test?

- A. Group A recalls more because the gray screen helped letter shapes stand out.
- B. Group B recalls more, because meaning-based processing is deeper.
- C. Both recall equally, since both saw each word once.
- D. Group A recalls more, because visual features are easier to remember.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A student who works at a campus bookstore hears a list of 15 words read aloud and is asked to recall them immediately. She lives in a dorm with a lake view. Which words is she most likely to recall best?

- A. Words at the beginning and end of the list.
- B. Only the first words.
- C. Words in the middle of the list.
- D. All words equally, since the list is short.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

If recall is delayed by 30 seconds of counting backward after the list, which part of the serial position curve changes most, and why?

- A. The recency effect disappears, because the last items were held only in short-term memory.
- B. The primacy effect disappears, because early items fade first.
- C. Middle items improve.
- D. Nothing changes.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

After weeks of news coverage about a rare shark attack at a popular beach town with a boardwalk, a family cancels their beach trip and drives 900 miles instead, believing driving is safer. Statistically, the drive carries far more risk. The family owns a minivan. Which heuristic is at work?

- A. Accurate risk judgment, since news coverage always reflects true risk.
- B. Availability heuristic.
- C. Anchoring.
- D. Representativeness heuristic.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Told that a quiet person who loves poetry was chosen from a group of 70 engineers and 30 librarians, most people guess “librarian.” Which heuristic produces this, and what is ignored?

- A.** Availability; the number of poems is ignored.
- B.** Anchoring on the number 70.
- C.** Representativeness; the base rate of 70% engineers is ignored.
- D.** Representativeness; the 30% librarian rate makes it correct.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A child who has a pet goldfish is shown pictures and asked whether each is a bird. She quickly says “yes” to a robin but hesitates for a penguin. Her classroom has a large window. Which theory best explains her faster response to the robin?

- A.** Prototype theory: the robin is closer to her averaged idea of a typical bird.
- B.** Definitional theory: penguins fail a required feature, so they are not birds.
- C.** Exemplar theory: she compares to one specific robin she remembers.
- D.** Her goldfish makes her unsure about all animals.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

Campers at a lakeside site with new picnic tables need to hang a lantern, but they have no hook. A carabiner on a backpack strap could clip it to a branch, but no one thinks of it because the carabiner is “for climbing gear.” The campsite has a fire ring. What blocked the solution?

- A.** Confirmation bias.
- B.** A lack of intelligence among the campers.
- C.** Mental set.
- D.** Functional fixedness.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A pharmacist at a busy chain store ~~with a drive-through~~ reads a smudged handwritten note that looks like "Take 1 t_blet daily" and immediately reads it as "tablet." ~~The note was written on blue paper.~~ Which process allowed her to fill in the missing letter?

Target word: processing direction **Decides:** Knowledge and context fill a gap in the input.

A	Adjacent category	Adaptation is reduced sensitivity to constant stimuli.
B	Inverted operation	Bottom-up works from the features alone, which are incomplete here.
C	Camouflage	Paper color does not supply the missing letter.
D	Correct	Expectations and knowledge shape interpretation of incomplete input.

2. Answer B Concept 1 · transfer

A person sees an unfamiliar abstract shape for the first time and identifies it by detecting its lines, angles, and edges. Which process is this?

Target word: processing direction when no prior knowledge applies **Decides:** Built from features without expectations.

A	Inverted operation	No prior knowledge or context is available for an unfamiliar shape.
B	Correct	Perception is built from sensory features.
C	Absolute language	No prototype exists for a never-seen abstract shape.
D	Confusion set	Chunking is a memory strategy, not a perceptual direction.

3. Answer D Concept 2

Radiologists at a teaching hospital ~~with a new MRI wing~~ are asked to search lung scans for nodules. In one scan, a small image of a gorilla is placed in the lung, and most radiologists miss it despite looking directly at that area. ~~The study took place on a Tuesday.~~ What best explains this?

Target word: why an obvious object was missed **Decides:** Focused attention on a task leaves unexpected objects unseen.

A	Adjacent category	Experts show the effect too; it reflects attention limits.
B	Confusion set	Change blindness is failing to notice a change between views.
C	Absolute language	Seeing is shaped by attention, not just by eyesight.
D	Correct	Attention focused on nodules leaves unexpected items unnoticed.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A nurse ~~who plays guitar on weekends~~ must remember an 11-digit account number: 18005551234. She thinks of it as "1-800," "555," and "1234," which are familiar patterns. ~~The number was printed on a green card.~~ Into how many chunks has she grouped the digits?

Target word: number of chunks **Decides:** Three familiar units.

A	Dropped element	Splits "1-800" into two units and ignores that she treats it as one pattern.
B	Confusion set	Borrows the classic 7 ± 2 capacity figure rather than counting her chunks.
C	Correct	"1-800," "555," and "1234" are three meaningful units.
D	Wrong stem number	Counts the individual digits, not chunks.

5. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

A person can hold about 4 chunks in working memory. If each chunk is a familiar 3-letter acronym, about how many letters can she hold?

Target word: solve for items from chunks **Decides:** Chunks × items per chunk.

A	Dropped element	Counts chunks only and ignores what each contains.
B	Inverted operation	Divides 4 by 3 instead of multiplying.
C	Correct	4 chunks × 3 letters = 12.
D	Wrong stem number	Uses the classic capacity figure instead of the stem's numbers.

6. Answer B Concept 4

In a study run in a lab ~~with soundproof walls~~, group A decides whether each word is printed in capital letters, and group B decides whether each word fits the sentence “She put the ___ on the table.” ~~The words appeared on a gray screen.~~ Which result is expected on a surprise recall test?

Target word: which group remembers more **Decides:** Meaning-based vs. appearance-based processing.

A	Camouflage	Screen color does not decide the result.
B	Correct	Semantic encoding produces stronger memory traces.
C	Dropped element	Ignores the depth of processing.
D	Inverted operation	Shallow processing yields weaker memory.

7. Answer A Concept 5

A student ~~who works at a campus bookstore~~ hears a list of 15 words read aloud and is asked to recall them immediately. ~~She lives in a dorm with a lake view.~~ Which words is she most likely to recall best?

Target word: recall pattern with immediate test **Decides:** Immediate recall shows both primacy and recency.

A	Correct	Primacy and recency both appear on immediate recall.
B	Dropped element	Drops the recency effect present on immediate recall.
C	Inverted operation	Middle items are recalled worst.
D	Absolute language	Fifteen items is well above working-memory capacity.

8. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

If recall is delayed by 30 seconds of counting backward after the list, which part of the serial position curve changes most, and why?

Target word: which effect disappears with delay **Decides:** Recency depends on short-term memory.

A	Correct	The distraction displaces items from short-term memory.
B	Inverted operation	Early items were rehearsed into long-term memory and survive the delay.
C	Adjacent category	Nothing in a delay helps middle items.
D	Dropped element	Drops the role of short-term memory in recency.

9. Answer B Concept 6

After weeks of news coverage about a rare shark attack at a popular beach town ~~with a boardwalk~~, a family cancels their beach trip and drives 900 miles instead, believing driving is safer. Statistically, the drive carries far more risk. ~~The family owns a minivan.~~ Which heuristic is at work?

Target word: heuristic **Decides:** Vivid, easily recalled examples inflate perceived risk.

A	Absolute language	Coverage tracks vividness, not frequency.
B	Correct	Heavy coverage makes the rare event come to mind easily.
C	Adjacent category	No initial number shaped their estimate.
D	Confusion set	That is judging by resemblance to a prototype, not ease of recall.

10. Answer C Concept 6 · transfer

Told that a quiet person who loves poetry was chosen from a group of 70 engineers and 30 librarians, most people guess “librarian.” Which heuristic produces this, and what is ignored?

Target word: name the heuristic and the neglected fact **Decides:** Similarity to a stereotype overrides base rates.

A	Confusion set	The judgment is about resemblance, not ease of recall.
B	Wrong stem number	People ignore the 70 rather than anchor on it.
C	Correct	Resemblance to a librarian stereotype outweighs the higher odds of an engineer.
D	Inverted operation	Only 30% are librarians, so “engineer” is more likely.

11. Answer A Concept 7

A child ~~who has a pet goldfish~~ is shown pictures and asked whether each is a bird. She quickly says “yes” to a robin but hesitates for a penguin. ~~Her classroom has a large window.~~ Which theory best explains her faster response to the robin?

Target word: categorization model **Decides:** Faster when closer to an averaged typical example.

A	Correct	Typicality to a prototype speeds classification.
B	Adjacent category	She still classifies the penguin; she is only slower.
C	Confusion set	Exemplar theory relies on stored individual instances; the typicality gradient is the classic prototype account.
D	Camouflage	The pet is irrelevant to the pattern.

12. Answer D Concept 8

Campers at a lakeside site ~~with new picnic tables~~ need to hang a lantern, but they have no hook. A carabiner on a backpack strap could clip it to a branch, but no one thinks of it because the carabiner is “for climbing gear.” ~~The campsite has a fire ring.~~ What blocked the solution?

Target word: problem-solving obstacle **Decides:** An object seen only in its usual role.

A	Adjacent category	About seeking confirming evidence, not seeing new uses.
B	Absolute language	Functional fixedness affects people of all abilities.
C	Confusion set	Mental set is repeating a past method; here the block is about an object’s use.
D	Correct	They see the carabiner only in its usual function.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	3	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Bottom-up vs. top-down processing	Bottom-up processing builds perception from sensory features; top-down processing uses expectations, knowledge, and context to interpret input.	Calling context-driven reading of a blurry word bottom-up.	Ambiguous input resolved by context or expectation.
2	Selective attention and inattention blindness	Attention is limited; focusing on one task can make people miss clearly visible, unexpected events (inattention blindness).	Believing anything in plain sight will be noticed.	Someone focused on a task fails to see an obvious, unexpected object.
3	Working memory capacity and chunking	Working memory holds only a few units (about four chunks, or roughly 7 ± 2 items in older estimates); chunking groups items into meaningful units to fit more information.	Counting individual items instead of chunks.	A long string of digits or letters grouped into familiar units.
4	Levels of processing	Information processed for meaning (deep, semantic encoding) is remembered better than information processed for appearance or sound (shallow encoding).	Assuming more repetition alone guarantees better memory.	Judging a word's font or rhyme vs. its meaning.
5	Serial position effect	In free recall, the first items (primacy, from rehearsal into long-term memory) and the last items (recency, still in short-term memory) are best remembered; a delay before recall removes the recency effect.	Thinking a delay erases primacy rather than recency.	A list followed by immediate vs. delayed recall.
6	Heuristics in judgment	Availability judges likelihood by how easily examples come to mind; representativeness judges by similarity to a prototype while ignoring base rates; anchoring bends estimates toward an initial number.	Confusing availability (vivid memories) with representativeness (resemblance).	Recent vivid news, a stereotype-like description, or a starting number.
7	Prototype vs. exemplar categorization	Prototype theory classifies by similarity to an averaged best example; exemplar theory classifies by comparing to stored specific instances.	Mixing up an averaged ideal with remembered individual cases.	"Typical bird" vs. "reminds me of the specific birds I've seen."
8	Functional fixedness and mental set	Functional fixedness is seeing an object only in its usual function; mental set is sticking with a method that worked before even when a simpler one exists.	Treating these obstacles as a lack of intelligence.	An object that could solve the problem if used unusually, or a repeated method.

Course scope (public description): Cognitive Psychology examines human mental processes, including how humans sense, interpret, think about, and respond to information, and how they integrate new information with prior experience. This course examines mental operations, attention, pattern recognition and other perceptual processes, memory, problem-solving and decision-making, categorization and concept formation, language acquisition and use, and contextual-interpretation. There are no prerequisites for this course.